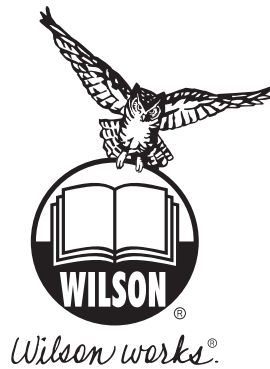


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Only in Australia PART ONE

Most of Australia's native animals aren't found anywhere else in the world. That's because Australia is sort of an evolutionary vacuum. You see, it separated from other continents about 30 million years ago. Since then, its wildlife evolved without outside influences. Two of the most popular critters are kangaroos and koalas.

When you think of Australia, you might visualize a kangaroo. Kangaroos are called "macropods," which means "big foot." With strong hind legs and large feet, they can jump more than 23 feet horizontally. They don't hop for recreation, but rather to get around. They are the tallest mammals in Australia. The red kangaroo stands over six feet tall. Kangaroos carry their babies, or joeys, in pouches and they travel in societies of around 50 called troops.

Kangaroos are most closely linked with Australia, but koalas come in a close second. They are easy to recognize with their large heads and round, furry ears. One distinguishing trait you can't see rests inside their heads. They have very small brains surrounded by fluid. Some scientists think that the fluid acts as a shock absorber when a koala falls from a tree. Koalas are picky eaters. Their diet mainly consists of leaves from the eucalyptus tree. These leaves are an inferior source of fuel for energy. Because of this, koalas quietly sleep up to twenty hours a day. Their geographic range extends throughout eastern Australia.

Over 80 percent of mammals and reptiles in Australia aren't found anywhere else on Earth. For that reason alone, it shouldn't take much to persuade us to learn more about them.

Only in Australia PART TWO

Kangaroos and koalas are Australia's most widely recognized mammals. In reality, there are many other mammals found only in Australia. A few of those include wallabies, bilbies, and platypuses.

Wallabies look like small kangaroos and their diets consist mostly of leaves. They were once the prey of foxes and dogs, but conservation work has successfully protected them.

If you visualize a mix of a rabbit and a rat, you'll see a bilby. These small mammals are quiet souls that live in tunnels. They eat a broad diet of insects, seeds, and fruit. Many Australians have been persuaded to switch from the Easter bunny to the Bilby bunny to support its conservation.

The platypus is found on the riverbanks of eastern Australia. It swims quietly through the water looking for

shellfish and insects. The first time you see a platypus, you might think that you've lost your grip on reality. This strange mammal has a bill like a duck, a tail like a beaver, and the webbed feet of an otter. When scientists first saw a platypus, they had no idea what they were looking at. They theorized that it was fake. Indeed, the platypus is very unusual. It is the only kind of mammal that lays eggs instead of giving birth to live babies. It's also one of the world's rare toxic mammals. A sharp stinger on the male's hind legs can deliver a deadly shot of poison to its enemies.

Several Australian museums have created websites about native wildlife, including videos and other sources of information. Check them out if you want to learn more!

Gardens Beneath the Sea PART ONE

What are seagrasses? They are like the grasses you see on land. They are distinguished from seaweed as true plants with roots, stems, leaves, and flowers. The leaves are called blades. You can see the individual blades growing in the water. The roots and stems grow under the sand. There are dozens of species of seagrass. Some have long flat blades that look like streamers. Others have blades shaped like ferns. They range in height from a few inches to thirty-five feet.

Seagrasses are found in salty and semi-salty waters. Some species, such as the Mediterranean tapeweed, grow in a single geographic location. However, eelgrass thrives in lots of places. Because seagrasses need sunlight, they grow in shallow

sunlit waters. They can't survive the impact of large waves, so they grow in the quiet waters of protected coastlines.

Seagrass plants that cover large areas are called seagrass meadows. These vast areas of seagrass haven't received as much attention as coral reefs, but in reality seagrass meadows influence their habitat in many ways that help the ocean. They are a major component of many sea organisms' diets. They create a buffer that lessens beach erosion during storms. Diverse forms of sea life coexist in the circuit of seagrass canopies. They reduce bacteria from polluted waters and they absorb carbon dioxide. These are some of the criteria that make seagrasses one of the most important ecosystems in the world.

Gardens Beneath the Sea PART TWO

A 2009 study evaluated the extent of seagrass loss since the late 1800s. It determined that seagrass meadows had declined by over twenty percent during that time. The causes and effects of seagrass loss are wide-ranging. The study delineated some of the biggest threats to seagrass such as disease and human activities.

Some seagrass meadows contain just a single species, such as tapeweed in the Mediterranean. This makes them vulnerable to disease. The largest recorded disease outbreak occurred in the 1930s. Diseased seagrass plants had distinguishing dark spots on the exterior of their blades. Called “wasting disease,” it permeated and ruined ninety percent of all eelgrass in the Atlantic Ocean.

The biggest threats to seagrass meadows are due to human activity. Dredging tears them up. It also disturbs silt, which then permeates the water. This grueling effect blocks light that seagrass depends on. Boat propellers create circuits of linear “scars” along the interiors of seagrass meadows. It can take years for seagrass to reappear in these bare areas. This is most common in areas with a lot of recreational boating. Pollutants in the runoff from roads and boat ramps also have an adverse influence on seagrass.

Awareness of the effects of human activity on the decline of seagrasses has grown since 2009. This may help persuade people from societies throughout the world to protect and restore these genuinely beautiful gardens beneath the sea.

Giftwrapping - How it All Began

The earliest known tradition of wrapping gifts can be traced to China, where paper was invented over two thousand years ago. Gifts of money for honored government leaders were wrapped in paper envelopes. In Japan, cloth has been a popular wrapper for gifts since the 1600s. At that same time, wealthy Europeans wrapped their presents in sheets of patterned wallpaper. To complete the wrapping, fancy knotted bows were added with handwritten notes under them.

The rolls of patterned paper we see in stores in the United States today, displayed in columns next to gift cards and ribbon, came about by chance. In 1917, a Kansas City stationery store ran out of the plain tissue paper they sold as gift wrap. When the owners stocked the empty shelves with sheets of patterned

envelope liners, they didn't go wrong. Customers never doubted that these elaborately designed papers would dress their gifts perfectly. Sales of the new kind of giftwrapping climbed quickly. No one at the time could know that decorative paper designed for wrapping gifts would become an entire industry within a few years.

In the U.S., giftwrapping paper remained a popular product throughout the 1900s. But since then, awareness of the impacts of paper products on the environment has grown. One estimate places the amount of trash created by wrapping paper and shopping bags in the U.S. at 4 million tons a year. Will people be persuaded to come up with less wasteful alternatives in the years to come? Only time will tell.

Robot Engineer

Megan joined the robotics club at her middle school when she was just twelve years old. Though she honestly didn't know it at the time, this was the first step toward her career in robotics engineering.

After middle school, Megan continued studying math and science with great effort. Even then, Megan wrestled with the sense that the world was changing. She undoubtedly saw signs that the robotic revolution was on the horizon. Megan was not wrong!

Megan became the president of the high school robotics club and applied to college to study engineering. During her senior year of college, Megan was assigned a three-month internship, or training. It was with a well-known company focused on

designing and building robots for health care. Megan was amazed by the significant amount of work and creativity involved in the development of these helpful robots. Megan was honored to assist the robotics engineers with all aspects of robot construction. She learned a lot during that time and it convinced her to continue her education. She wrapped up her master's degree in engineering by the age of 25.

Encouraged by her experience years ago, Megan now works as a robotics engineer, designing and building robots to help elderly people. Her robots provide companionship, reminders, entertainment, and even help with climbing stairs for older people who live alone.

Knighthood, Then and Now

In the Middle Ages, a knight was a mounted soldier in armor who fought to defend his king and country. Usually, a knight was granted the honor by the indebted ruler because he showed exceptional bravery and horsemanship on the battlefield. A touch of a sword by the reigning king or queen made it official.

A young boy could also become an apprentice and servant to a knight and work his way up to knighthood. In battle, knights wore metal plated armor that covered every part of their body, including their limbs.

Today, the idea of knighthood is less about defending the crown and more about contributing to the welfare of the country in other ways. In England,

a letter is sent out biannually inviting individuals to be knighted and they can accept the honor in writing. The king or queen makes the decision about whom to invite, but recommendations are made by the Secretary of State Defense and Secretary of Foreign and Commonwealth Affairs.

Well-known scientists, artists, athletes, writers, educators, and even rock stars - both men and women - have all been given the honor of knighthood. They don't get to wear armor like the knights of long ago, but they do get some unique garments and medals to wear to special events.

While knights have always served their country, the concept of knighthood has, no doubt, transformed since the Middle Ages.

What's a Gnu?

Gnus, more commonly known as wildebeests, are a type of large antelope found in Africa. Gnus are assigned to the Bovidae family, which includes goats, sheep, and cattle.

There are two different species of gnu; the brindled gnu and the white-tailed gnu. You can easily distinguish one gnu from the other by their appearance. The brindled gnu is gray with stripes and a blue hue. The white-tailed gnu has a mostly brown body with a light-colored tail. Brindled gnus are also larger than white-tailed gnus. Not only do they have distinctive appearances, but only brindled gnus can be found on an annual migratory climb with their symbiotic companions, the zebras.

Though they can vary considerably, there are many things that are true for all gnus. For instance,

you will not find any gnus gnawing on another animal. Despite a somewhat intimidating appearance, gnus are herbivores. They primarily gnaw on grass, but have been known to snack on leaves when food is scant. Additionally, hundreds of thousands of gnus are born each year knowing how to walk within minutes of birth. This is no design flaw. Gnus are resigned to travel a significant amount while in pursuit of resources. This quick-to-walk ability allows gnus to wrangle up their young easily for travel.

It would be wrong to doubt a gnu's adaptive abilities. Gnus are intelligent, protective, and highly mobile. These playful animals rarely become aggressive, and reign as expert foragers. For these reasons, gnus have always and will likely always maintain a healthy and prolific population.

Wallabies and Kangaroos

Kangaroos and wallabies are quite the scene in Australia. In fact, that's the only spot on Earth they call home. They belong to a group of mammals called marsupials. Marsupials start life in the warmth of their mother's special pouch, or pocket. It's called a marsupium. At around six months, the babies, called joeys, start climbing in and out. They wander freely while the mother keeps a watchful eye.

Some people think that size is the only quality that distinguishes kangaroos from wallabies. Kangaroos are the larger of the two. Both animals have large feet and strong legs for jumping. They also pound the ground with their feet when they want to warn others of danger. And those sturdy legs can serve a mighty kick to competitors that arrive on the scene.

While there are 30 species of wallabies, only six species of kangaroos exist. Kangaroos live for 20-25 years. Wallabies live for 11-14 years. Another difference is the quality of their coats. Wallaby fur contains bright shades of orange, while kangaroo fur is limited to dull tones of brown and gray.

Kangaroos and wallabies both enjoy a diet of vegetable matter, such as grasses and leaves. Like cows, they chew and swallow their food twice. They have adapted to Australia's dry climate by getting most of their water from food. Both travel in groups. They sleep during the day when the heat is at its worst. At night, they graze while the air is warm.

Without a doubt, these critters have a lot in common, but if you watch them closely, you'll see the differences.

An Alaskan Whale Watch

The captain made a final circuit around the engine room before inviting the passengers to board the sixty-foot whale-watching vessel. She requested that the passengers divide themselves equally on each side of the boat. It would be an eight-hour cruise with plenty of opportunities to watch some of the world's largest marine mammals, including humpback whales, killer whales, and the Pacific walrus.

Julia was a marine photographer aboard the scenic cruise, and she was hoping to get lots of quality photos of the rich marine life along Alaska's coastline. She saw a walrus taking a nap on a patch of sea ice, but it was too far away for a close-up.

Not long after, she noticed people pointing excitedly off the forward port quarter of the boat. She wandered over there and was rewarded with the sight of several killer whales playfully breaching, or leaping from the water. Julia got a great photo of one in mid-air. It was delightful to see the whales splashing back down into the water one after another.

Without warning, the smooth water became quite choppy and strong winds began to settle in. Julia quickly swallowed an anti-seasick pill. The weather worsened with each passing minute, and the captain announced that they would have to return to the harbor early. They would miss getting to see a humpback whale today. Despite this, the whale-watching cruise had been very worthwhile for Julia and the other passengers.

The Tooth-Walking Sea Horse PART ONE

The walrus is a large marine mammal that can be found inhabiting the freezing cold, icy waters of the Arctic Circle. In warmer summer months, when the ice recedes, walruses often migrate to the shores of the more remote areas of the rocky coastline. Walruses climb up on beaches or ice to sleep or to rest. They are very fat, and for good reason. Their blubber qualifies as a kind of insulation, keeping them warm and helping them to store energy. These animals can also slow their heart rates, which allows them to live in a cold environment.

Walruses have large, elongated bodies that are wider at the head and neck and taper toward their tail. Their wrinkled skin is brown and pink. They have two pairs of flippers which help to propel them through the

water. Their front flippers are used to steer them in the right direction, while back flippers supply them with power. Their aquatic abilities are something to behold. The skin on the flippers is thick and rough, providing traction while waddling around on land and ice.

Walruses have very noteworthy tusks. In fact, the tusks are elongated canine teeth which can grow to be about three feet long! They use their tusks to dig into the ice when they are pulling their gigantic bodies out of the frigid seawater. The Latin name for walrus translates as “tooth-walking sea horse.” When underwater, the tusks are used to help them carve breathing holes from down below into the thick ice above. In worse case scenarios, male walruses use their tusks as weapons to establish dominance.

The Tooth-Walking Sea Horse PART TWO

Walruses have long, coarse whiskers that are very sensitive and most useful when looking for food. Walruses find their food in the shallow, murky underwater of the ocean scene. They can dive to almost 300 feet and stay under the water for approximately 30 minutes.

Walruses feed on clams, worms, snails, squid, and slow-moving fish. Walruses suck their food into their mouths like a vacuum rather than use their teeth to chew on it. Walruses also prey on seals and narwhals if they are trapped by ice. Clearly a vegetable diet is not part of the walrus' marine meal plan!

These large beasts swarm together on ice floes and on shore. Herds of walruses can range into the

hundreds. Walruses look like they waddle when they move on land, but they can move pretty fast if they need to. They hobble on all fours like a dog and can run as fast as a human being.

In general, walruses live to be 20-30 years old and spend about two thirds of their life in water. Because walruses dwarf most other aquatic animals, they have just two main predators - the orca, or killer whales, and polar bears. And both of these predators prefer to attack smaller prey such as seals.

There was a time when the Atlantic population of walruses was hunted to the point of near extinction. Now, hunting these tooth-walking sea horses is mostly illegal.

Monarch Butterflies PART ONE

Monarch caterpillars can be found all across North America. They are striped with yellow, black, and white bands and can grow to be two inches long. They feed on the leaves of milkweed plants. These wildflower plants have an opaque milky juice inside of them. The milkweed produces a chemical-like substance which stops animals from eating them. Interestingly, monarch caterpillars are unaffected by these distasteful chemicals. Because they store up the poison-like substance in their own bodies, this biological mechanism is like built-in protection from other animals. You see, other animals can't stomach the terrible taste of monarch caterpillar. The substance remains in the caterpillars' systems even after they change into adult butterflies.

Monarch butterflies are broken up into two distinct populations separated by the Rocky Mountains - the eastern and the western populations.

These flying insects have two sets of wings. The wings are about two to four inches in length. The unique markings of the monarch butterfly make it very recognizable. They have a bright, deep orange and black coloring. They also have white spots on the edges of their wings while the underside of their wings is pale orange. Their bodies are black with white markings. Monarch butterflies are considered by many to be the most beautiful of all butterflies – some would say the “king” of butterflies, hence the name “monarch.”

Monarch Butterflies PART TWO

Monarch butterflies living in Canada and the United States are probably best known for the mighty migration they make each year. When the cool autumn air settles in, the monarchs know that food and warmth will soon be scarce. Thus, millions of these flying insects begin heading south. They continue on their journey to Southern California or central Mexico. In some cases, that's more than 2,000 miles to conquer!

On schedule, millions of monarchs amazingly return to the same forests every year. Some even anchor themselves to the same exact tree as their ancestors. It's not clear how the monarchs are able to do this. It goes without saying that it's not due to the use of technology. However, it's even more surprising when you realize

monarchs are not just repeating a learned technique. You see, they never make the journey more than once during their lifetime. That's because monarchs don't live longer than eight months.

We also don't know how the butterflies know which way to go, but we do know why they go. Before the end of winter, the monarchs mate. The males then die and the females take off to fly back north. On their way, they lay their eggs on milkweed plants before they, too, die.

Scholars believe that monarchs in North America have been conquering this unique journey for thousands of years. Supporting the efforts of conserving these monarch overwintering spots is important to the survival of these beautiful butterflies.

Archipelagoes

An archipelago is a grouping of islands that are in close proximity, or a group of islands within a specific location, like the Antilles of the Caribbean. There are several unique types of archipelagoes, each with distinctive characteristics.

It may pique your interest to learn the majority of archipelagoes are actually the result of erupted volcanoes. These not-so-scarce archipelagoes are called oceanic islands. A series of chaotic eruptions dating back 80 million years formed one example of this type of archipelago, the islands of Hawaii.

Rising sea levels and erosion can also build the schematics for archipelagoes. These islands are on a slow-moving schedule, building up gradually as sediment attaches to the reefs below. An example of these coral cay archipelagoes is the Florida Keys.

Continental fragments, or microcontinents, are actually pieces of larger land masses that split off from tectonic shifts. These islands lose their anchor to the mainland and shift away.

Continental archipelagoes, on the other hand, are merely islands that formed near the coast of major land masses. Historically, many of these types of islands were conquered by the nearest monarch because of their proximity to the mainland.

Some archipelagoes are chameleons of sorts. While scholarly research would show an island belongs to a specific archipelago, they may be characterized differently as a result of political boundaries.

Even with all these types of archipelagoes, it is not enough for some scheming architects. The Palm Islands of Dubai are actually a man-made archipelago!

Echolocation

Echolocation is a type of sonar animals use to conquer the challenges of travel. The animal produces a sound that disperses into the environment, and listens for the returning echoes to determine what is near them and where they must go. This technique allows the echolocating animal to travel unimpeded and supports hunting and foraging efforts when food is scarce.

Some species, like bats, rely heavily on echolocation to anchor their travel. Bats are nocturnal and schedule their hunting during the night. Their eyes are sensitive to light, which makes the mechanics of flight more chaotic. They need echolocation to safely traverse narrow caves and locate insects for sustenance.

Dolphins also use echolocation to find food, home, and family. They make a unique clicking sound that has piqued the interest of marine biologists. The clicking

sound is actually a burst pulse that has to be channeled. Many echolocating marine mammals have physiques that support fat deposits so they can fuel this energy-draining pulse. As seen with noise pollution, interrupting or jamming marine echolocation can have devastating consequences, like organ damage and accidental beaching.

Echolocation isn't a characteristic exclusive to bats and marine life. Many types of birds and some types of shrews use echolocation. Scholars have suggested hedgehogs may also use echolocation. Even some people with visual impairments have conquered echolocation, without the use of adaptive technology.

Given its day-to-day impact on navigation and diet, there is no doubt echolocation plays a critical role in orchestrating the lives of the animals that use it.

St. Lucia

Who isn't curious about a trip to the Caribbean? With impressive natural landscapes, beautiful beaches, and a rich culture, the Caribbean's St. Lucia is a great place to head for a future adventure.

The Pitons, two mountainous volcanic plugs located on the southwestern coast, are a fixture of this island nation. Many individuals take coastal tours just to see them. It is unsurprising that many come for these signature views. These enormous structures stand approximately 2500 feet high! There are also several unique plants and animals that call the Pitons home. This means the best way to capture the full experience is to head inland after the tour for a nature hike. There are numerous trails to try.

For those picturing a more leisurely trip, St. Lucia has several choices. For instance, there are numerous lovely beaches throughout the island. At night, these beaches often play host to special social events. Many visitors also enjoy relaxing at Sulphur Springs. This dormant, or inactive, volcano has mud baths that are said to heal. Afterward, visitors can wash up in the natural waterfalls. Just beware, the springs do stink!

When visitors prefer a mixture of fun and learning, they head to the famous Pigeon Island. With a rich and engaging history involving pirates, there is a lot to learn. For those who appreciate marine life, there are several potential water activities to try as well.

With so many places to go and things to do, the hardest decision to be made in St. Lucia is where to head first!

A Trip to an Egyptian Pyramid

Omari, an Egyptian tour guide, waits at the hotel to pick up Maria and her best friend Antonio. The pair of friends will be visiting a culturally important structure built more than 4,000 years ago.

Omari enthusiastically greets Maria and Antonio. He then explains that the scheduled adventure will last four hours. It includes a tour of the famous Great Pyramid of Giza, a camel ride, and some shopping. After their departure from the hotel, Maria and Antonio are already curious. They capitalize on the time they have with an expert on Egyptian pyramids. They learn that the Great Pyramid of Giza is a national fixture. Additionally, it's the only one of the original Seven Wonders of the Ancient World that is still standing.

Maria and Antonio enter the phenomenal pyramid. They walk down a corridor covered in rocky soil. From there, a passageway leads to the Queen's Chamber. Next, Maria and Antonio make their way to a room lined continuously with hard rock known as granite. Omari explains that this enclosure is known as the King's Chamber and it's an architectural wonder. The flat roof is made of nine enormous pink granite blocks that support the pressure of over 400 tons of rock above.

As the educational pyramid exploration comes to an end, Maria and Antonio head out to begin their camel ride to the outside local market of shops. They end their day by capturing some photos of the Great Pyramid and expressing their appreciation to Omari for his especially efficient and personal tour.

The Aleutian Islands

The Aleutian Islands, previously known as the Catherine Archipelago, is a substantially long chain of islands in the Pacific Ocean. The curvature, or arc, of islands spans from Alaska to Russia, sectioning off the Bering Sea. There are numerous volcanic islands within the boundaries, and a mixture of smaller islands as well. The majority of the Aleutian islands are officially part of Alaska. However, some geographically Aleutian islands are part of Russia.

The Aleutian islands are famous for their diverse and plentiful indigenous animal life. Historically, several types of birds have become fixtures on these islands. From puffins to geese, more than 10 million nests can be found in a given year. The Aleutian

islands also support creatures off land too, including sea lions, otters, and humpback whales.

The islands have more than just amazing animals associated with them. An ancient and rich culture has persevered there despite numerous challenges. The Aleut people have been on these islands for over 9,000 years. They built villages along the seacoasts and gave Alaska its name, “The Great Land.” The Aleuts were brutally attacked and captured, then faced atrocious diseases that almost eliminated their population. Today, there are only a small number of Aleut villages.

Filled with a variety of biological, geographical, and historical marvels, the Aleutian Islands are part of an ancient and unique ocean environment.

The Wombat

The word “wombat” means “of little worth” in an ancient Aboriginal Australian language. Yet, this marsupial is the official fauna emblem of South Australia. There are three species of these curious creatures and they are the world’s largest burrowing animal.

The wombat has a stocky body with short, muscular legs. Its fur is a mixture of grey and black. You can see a likeness with the koala in some facial features, especially the spoon-shaped nose. Unlike their jumping marsupial cousins, wombats walk and run with all four legs. Their long, thick claws are essential for digging burrows. Although they look like cute bears, they can be vicious when threatened.

Wombats are completely herbivorous. They eat some pretty tough stuff, like roots and moss. But they

have a special gland in their stomachs to help digest those foods efficiently.

Wombats call a wide range of southeast Australia home. They live in complex burrows that can be 100 feet long and over 11 feet deep. The burrows are often connected by tunnels. Some house one or two wombats, and others larger family groups. The wombat's social structure depends on the species. Some like a social scene, and others are loners. The more social wombats live in groups called “mobs” or “colonies.”

Early in the 20th century, wombats were hunted for their furs. However, that has stopped and wombat conservation is now well established. Only the northern hairy-nosed wombat is critically endangered. But there is good reason to hope that they will again become fixtures of the Australian wilds.

Threats to the Prairie Dogs

Hundreds of millions of prairie dogs used to occupy the plains of America. Today, less than 5% of the original population exists. Many factors caused this disappearance. One major cause was the decreasing environment. The arrival of settlers and farmers meant less room for prairie dogs. Efforts to coexist have not always ended in great result for prairie dogs.

The tunneling and eating behaviors of prairie dogs have been perceived as major annoyances. The hunting and poisoning of prairie dogs illustrates the assumption that we can't commune with this species. However, opportunities exist to explore successful solutions.

In addition to negative interactions with humans, prairie dogs also face the threat of disease. The plague, a non-native disease, affects rodents such as prairie

dogs. Apparently, communities of prairie dogs are easily affected by this deadly disease. The plague is transmitted by fleas. It's caused by the same bacteria that is responsible for the Black Death. This was a widespread and destructive plague that appeared in Europe and Asia in the 1300s.

To help fight the prairie dog plague as it is sometimes called, researchers accomplished a huge triumph - a vaccine. With great effort, they developed a peanut butter-flavored bait that can be distributed in the area of the prairie dog towns. Once eaten, the vaccine protects the prairie dogs from dying from the plague. We know this plague is quite dangerous for the prairie dogs. However, we can take comfort in knowing that is not easily passed on to humans.

Accomplishing Great Things!

Dear Reader,

An individual can accomplish so much in a single lifetime. Willingness to fight for important beliefs is essential and this begins with belief in one's self. This must be supported and developed without compromise. In the end, determination is the key!

Humans have great potential. The burning desire within must be fanned into a brilliant flame. Each accomplishment is a momentous stride forward. Each effort and achievement is a stepping-stone to greater things.

Be assured that with the completion of Step 12, you can read most anything! Continue to develop your comprehension and understanding of language. Stay curious by discovering new words and investigating their

meanings. You must read - read - read to successfully meet your future challenges!

Spelling may continue to be challenging, but the more you write, the more comfortable you will be with expressing yourself in writing. Allow yourself to use your notebook as a resource. Don't be afraid to take a risk!

Please accept my congratulations on this enormous accomplishment. Your performance is commendable and you should be applauded. Take time to pat yourself on the back in a very big way. Be proud and take time to celebrate this important occasion. Then ask yourself, "What is my next goal?" and "How can I make life better for myself and those that I love?"

I am so very honored that you have been a student in this program.

Affectionately, Barbara A. Wilson